

A FIVE-DAY RETREAT IN DAILY LIFE

Be Still

Five Days with the Psalms of Trust



DAY ONE The Lord Is My Shepherd *Psalms 23*

DAY TWO Be Still, and Know *Psalms 46:1-11*

DAY THREE I Lift Up My Eyes *Psalms 121*

DAY FOUR Like a Weaned Child *Psalms 131*

DAY FIVE You Have Searched Me *Psalms 139:1-12*

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IGNATIUS AT HOME

How to Pray These Days



The Psalms are the prayer book Jesus himself prayed. Among them is a small family of songs of trust: prayers for people who are frightened, worn out, far from home, or simply unsure that anyone is watching over them. They do not pretend that life is calm. The waters roar, the valley is dark, the night comes. But in the middle of it, someone says: you are with me.

For the next five days, spend one time of prayer a day with one of these psalms. About twenty to thirty minutes is enough. Let each painting slow you down and help you enter the psalm with your imagination.

EACH DAY

- 1. Become still.** Find a quiet place. Sit comfortably, breathe slowly, and become aware that God is already present, looking at you with love.
- 2. Ask for the grace.** Each day names a grace. Ask for it plainly, as something you really want. Desire is where prayer begins.
- 3. Read slowly.** Read the psalm aloud if you can, and then read it again. Stay with any word or line that holds you; there is no need to finish.
- 4. Look.** Spend a few minutes with the painting. Where are you in it? What do you notice, and what do you feel as you look?
- 5. Speak as a friend.** End by talking with God in your own words, as one friend speaks to another. Close with the Our Father.
- 6. Notice.** Afterwards, take a moment to notice what stirred: consolation or desolation, peace or resistance. Jot down a word if it helps.

On the last day, or on a sixth day if you can, return to the psalm that moved you most and pray it again.

THE DAYS

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DAY ONE

The Lord Is My Shepherd

Psalms 23



The Good Shepherd, Bartolomé Esteban Murillo, c. 1660

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to know, deep down, that I am shepherded, and that with God I lack nothing I truly need.

FOCUS

Let the Shepherd lead you beside still waters, and notice where in your life you are being invited to lie down and rest.

¹ Yahweh is my shepherd:
I shall lack nothing.
² He makes me lie down in green pastures.
He leads me beside still waters.
³ He restores my soul.
He guides me in the paths of righteousness for his
name's sake.

⁴ Even though I walk through the valley of the
shadow of death,
I will fear no evil, for you are with me.
Your rod and your staff,
they comfort me.
⁵ You prepare a table before me
in the presence of my enemies.
You anoint my head with oil.
My cup runs over.
⁶ Surely goodness and loving kindness shall follow
me all the days of my life,
and I will dwell in Yahweh's house forever.

DAY TWO

Be Still, and Know

Psalm 46:1-11



The Ninth Wave, Ivan Aivazovsky, 1850

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to be still in the midst of upheaval, and to know that God is God, and that I do not have to be.

FOCUS

Name the waters that are roaring in your life right now, and listen beneath them for the voice that says, “Be still.”

¹ God is our refuge and strength,
a very present help in trouble.

² Therefore we won't be afraid, though the earth
changes,
though the mountains are shaken into the heart of
the seas;

³ though its waters roar and are troubled,
though the mountains tremble with their swelling.
Selah.

⁴ There is a river, the streams of which make the city
of God glad,
the holy place of the tents of the Most High.

⁵ God is within her. She shall not be moved.
God will help her at dawn.

⁶ The nations raged. The kingdoms were moved.
He lifted his voice, and the earth melted.

⁷ Yahweh of Armies is with us.
The God of Jacob is our refuge.
Selah.

⁸ Come, see Yahweh's works,
what desolations he has made in the earth.

⁹ He makes wars cease to the end of the earth.
He breaks the bow, and shatters the spear.
He burns the chariots in the fire.

¹⁰ “Be still, and know that I am God.
I will be exalted among the nations.
I will be exalted in the earth.”

¹¹ Yahweh of Armies is with us.
The God of Jacob is our refuge.
Selah.

DAY THREE

I Lift Up My Eyes

Psalm 121



Morning in the Riesengebirge, Caspar David Friedrich, 1810–1811

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to lift my eyes from my worries, and to trust the One who keeps me and never slumbers or sleeps.

FOCUS

Offer God every going out and coming in of your day, and let him keep watch over each one.

1 I will lift up my eyes to the hills.
Where does my help come from?

2 My help comes from Yahweh,
who made heaven and earth.

3 He will not allow your foot to be moved.
He who keeps you will not slumber.

4 Behold, he who keeps Israel
will neither slumber nor sleep.

5 Yahweh is your keeper.
Yahweh is your shade on your right hand.

6 The sun will not harm you by day,
nor the moon by night.

7 Yahweh will keep you from all evil.
He will keep your soul.

8 Yahweh will keep your going out and your coming
in,
from this time forward, and forever more.

DAY FOUR

Like a Weaned Child

Psalm 131



The Tempi Madonna, Raphael, 1508

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace of a quieted soul, content to rest in God like a child held by its mother.

FOCUS

Set down one great matter that is too wonderful for you, and simply let yourself be held.

¹ Yahweh, my heart isn't haughty, nor my eyes lofty;
nor do I concern myself with great matters,
or things too wonderful for me.

² Surely I have stilled and quieted my soul,
like a weaned child with his mother,
like a weaned child is my soul within me.

³ Israel, hope in Yahweh,
from this time forward and forever more.

You Have Searched Me

Psalm 139:1-12



The Starry Night, Vincent van Gogh, 1889

THE GRACE

Ask for the grace to know that I am fully known and fully loved, and that there is nowhere I could go beyond God's reach.

FOCUS

Bring God the place in you that feels darkest, and hear that even the darkness is not dark to him.

1 Yahweh, you have searched me,
and you know me.

2 You know my sitting down and my rising up.
You perceive my thoughts from afar.

3 You search out my path and my lying down,
and are acquainted with all my ways.

4 For there is not a word on my tongue,
but, behold, Yahweh, you know it altogether.

5 You hem me in behind and before.
You laid your hand on me.

6 This knowledge is beyond me.
It's lofty.
I can't attain it.

7 Where could I go from your Spirit?
Or where could I flee from your presence?

8 If I ascend up into heaven, you are there.
If I make my bed in Sheol, behold, you are there!

9 If I take the wings of the dawn,
and settle in the uttermost parts of the sea;

10 Even there your hand will lead me,
and your right hand will hold me.

11 If I say, "Surely the darkness will overwhelm me;
the light around me will be night";

12 even the darkness doesn't hide from you,
but the night shines as the day.
The darkness is like light to you.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Credits



SCRIPTURE

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PAINTINGS

DAY ONE

Bartolomé Esteban Murillo (1617–1682), *The Good Shepherd*, c. 1660. Museo del Prado, Madrid. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY TWO

Ivan Aivazovsky (1817–1900), *The Ninth Wave*, 1850. State Russian Museum, Saint Petersburg. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY THREE

Caspar David Friedrich (1774–1840), *Morning in the Riesenberge*, 1810–1811. Charlottenburg Palace, Berlin (Prussian Palaces and Gardens Foundation). Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FOUR

Raphael (1483–1520), *The Tempi Madonna*, 1508. Alte Pinakothek, Munich. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

DAY FIVE

Vincent van Gogh (1853–1890), *The Starry Night*, 1889. Museum of Modern Art, New York. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

TYPE

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